

Validation Source Identity & Attribution Module (VSIAM)

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Governed Space

Validation Source Identity & Attribution

Canonical Definition

Validation Source Identity & Attribution Module (VSIAM) defines the governance framework for establishing, distinguishing, recording, and maintaining the identity of sources materially contributing to Validation Evidence and for determining whether specific evidence can be sufficiently attributed to the source, source instance, source version, or source role claimed to have generated, observed, measured, recorded, supplied, transmitted, transformed, or interpreted it.

It establishes the first source-qualification condition within VALIDOS®:

Before source reliability can be assessed, the relevant source must be sufficiently identifiable and the evidence-source relationship sufficiently attributable.

Operational Role

VSIAM serves as the first internal governance space of the Validation Source Reliability Standard.

Its primary questions are:

Who or what is the source?

and:

Can the Validation Evidence be sufficiently attributed to that source?

The governed progression is:

Validation Evidence → Candidate Source → Source Identification → Source Distinguishability → Source Role Identification → Attribution Assessment → Identified & Attributed Validation Source

VSIAM does not determine whether the source is reliable.

It establishes the source identity and attribution basis upon which subsequent Source Reliability governance depends.

Module Operational Space

VSIAM governs:

- validation-source identification,
- source distinguishability,
- source identity precision,
- source-instance identification,
- source-version identification,
- source-role identification,
- source attribution,
- direct attribution,
- derived attribution,
- intermediated attribution,
- aggregated attribution,
- uncertain attribution,
- unattributed evidence,
- multi-source attribution,
- attribution strength,
- attribution boundaries,
- attribution conflicts,
- attribution limitations,
- attribution change,
- identity continuity,
- attribution continuity,
- and source-attribution traceability.

Module Function

VSIAM applies whenever Validation Evidence depends upon one or more sources whose identity or contribution may materially affect validation.

Its function is to prevent:

- anonymous evidence being treated as fully attributable,
- organizations being confused with individual evidence generators,
- platforms being mistaken for original sources,
- documents being treated as their own origin,
- source versions being silently mixed,
- evidence generated by one system instance being attributed to another,
- intermediaries being mistaken for primary sources,
- multiple sources being collapsed into one attribution,
- one source being represented as several independent sources,
- AI-generated transformations being detached from the systems that produced them,
- and uncertain attribution being converted into assumed attribution.

Validation Source Identity

A Validation Source is any entity capable of materially contributing to Validation Evidence.

Depending upon the validation context, a source may be:

- a person,
- organization,
- laboratory,
- institution,
- sensor,
- measuring instrument,
- software system,
- AI model,
- autonomous system,
- database,
- dataset origin,
- operational process,
- repository,
- monitoring system,
- document origin,
- external service,
- or another identifiable evidence-producing or evidence-handling entity.

Source identity must be sufficiently precise for the role the source performs.

Source Identity Is Role-Dependent

Different validation roles require different levels of identity precision.

For one validation, identifying an organization may be sufficient.

Another may require identification of:

- the specific laboratory,
- specific instrument,
- specific operator,
- specific model,
- specific model version,
- specific sensor,
- specific system instance,
- or specific dataset release.

VSIAM therefore establishes:

Source identity precision should be proportionate to the evidentiary role and consequence of reliance.

Source Entity and Source Instance

VSIAM distinguishes:

Source Entity

from:

Source Instance

For example:

A manufacturer may be the Source Entity.

A particular calibrated device may be the Source Instance.

An AI provider may be the Source Entity.

A specific deployed model version may be the Source Instance.

Where instance-level differences materially affect evidence, entity-level identification alone is insufficient.

Source Version

Sources can change.

A model may be updated.

A database may receive a new release.

A measurement instrument may be recalibrated.

A software system may change configuration.

A methodology may be revised.

VSIAM therefore permits source identity to include the version,

release, configuration, calibration state, or other materially relevant source state.

Source Role

A source may perform one or several evidentiary roles.

Possible roles include:

Evidence Originator

Observer

Measurement Source

Recorder

Provider

Transmitter

Transformer

Aggregator

Interpreter

Repository

Custodian

The same source may perform multiple roles.

Each role should remain distinguishable where it materially affects later Source Reliability assessment.

Identity Before Reliability

VALIDOS® establishes the sequencing rule:

Source Identity → Source Attribution → Source Reliability

A source cannot be meaningfully assessed for:

- competence,
- independence,
- conflicts,
- capability,
- provenance,
- or reliability

until the source itself has been sufficiently identified.

Where source identity remains materially unresolved, later reliability claims must remain correspondingly limited.

Evidence Attribution

Attribution establishes the governed relationship between Validation Evidence and the source claimed to have materially contributed it.

The core relationship is:

Evidence Item → Source Contribution → Source Identity → Attribution Status

Attribution should describe what the source actually contributed.

It should not merely identify the entity from which the validator received the evidence.

Provider Is Not Necessarily Origin

VALIDOS® establishes:

Evidence Provider ≠ Evidence Origin

A report may be supplied by one organization while relying upon measurements produced by another.

A database may provide information originally collected elsewhere.

An AI system may summarize information originating from external sources.

A regulator may publish data reported by regulated entities.

VSIAM preserves this distinction.

Direct Attribution

Evidence has **Direct Attribution** where the relationship between evidence and the source that generated, observed, measured, or recorded it can be sufficiently established without a material intermediary obscuring that relationship.

Direct attribution may provide a stronger attribution basis.

It does not automatically establish source reliability.

Derived Attribution

Evidence has **Derived Attribution** where its evidentiary content originates through another identifiable source, dataset,

measurement, record, or evidentiary object.

Derived attribution must preserve the fact that the immediate source is not necessarily the original evidence origin.

Detailed provenance and lineage are governed separately within VSRS.

Intermediated Attribution

Evidence has **Intermediated Attribution** where one or more entities stand between the original source contribution and the validation process.

Examples may include:

- data brokers,
- publishers,
- aggregators,
- platforms,
- translation systems,
- analytical services,
- reporting organizations,
- or software intermediaries.

VSIAM identifies the attribution relationship.

Subsequent VSRS governance determines the implications of the intermediary chain for source reliability.

Aggregated Attribution

Evidence may combine contributions from multiple sources.

Examples include:

- aggregated datasets,
- meta-analyses,
- composite indicators,
- multi-sensor systems,
- combined operational records,
- or ensemble outputs.

Where individual source contributions cannot be separated, the evidence should not be falsely attributed to a single source.

VSIAM permits attribution to an identifiable source set, aggregation mechanism, or composite source structure.

Multi-Source Attribution

Some evidence legitimately depends upon multiple sources.

VSIAM may represent:

Evidence Item → Source A + Source B + Source C

where each source performs a distinguishable role.

Multi-source attribution prevents complex evidence chains from being simplified into misleading single-source representations.

Attribution Strength

Attribution may possess different levels of evidentiary strength.

Possible classifications may include:

Verified Attribution

Strong Attribution

Supported Attribution

Conditional Attribution

Uncertain Attribution

Unattributed

The required classification structure may vary by implementation.

The essential requirement is that attribution uncertainty remains visible.

Verified Attribution

Verified Attribution exists where the evidence-source relationship has been established through sufficiently strong identifying and attribution mechanisms appropriate to the validation context.

These mechanisms may include:

- authenticated records,
- cryptographic evidence,
- controlled system records,
- signed documentation,
- verified measurement pathways,
- or another proportionate mechanism.

Verification strengthens attribution.

It does not independently establish source reliability.

Conditional Attribution

Evidence may be attributable only if one or more assumptions remain valid.

For example:

- attribution depends upon an unverified system record,
- the source identity is known but the exact version is uncertain,
- an intermediary claims the original source,
- or a source contribution cannot be fully separated from others.

These conditions must remain attached to the attribution record.

Uncertain Attribution

Where available information suggests a source relationship but does not establish it sufficiently, VSIAM preserves:

Attribution Uncertain

rather than converting probability into certainty.

This is especially important for:

- historical records,
 - scraped data,
 - online information,
 - AI-generated content,
 - undocumented datasets,
 - inherited databases,
 - or complex evidence chains.
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Unattributed Evidence

Evidence may sometimes have no sufficiently identifiable source.

Unattributed evidence is not automatically false.

However, the inability to establish source identity materially constrains subsequent Source Reliability governance.

VSIAM therefore distinguishes:

Evidence Exists

from:

Attribution Boundary

Attribution should remain bounded to what can actually be established.

For example:

A document may be reliably attributable to an organization.

That does not automatically establish which individual:

- created it,
- reviewed it,
- approved it,
- generated its underlying data,
- or authored every statement within it.

VSIAM prevents attribution from expanding beyond the evidence available.

Attribution Conflict

An Attribution Conflict exists where:

- multiple sources claim origin,
- records identify different sources,
- metadata conflicts with documentation,
- source versions cannot be reconciled,
- or competing attribution pathways exist.

Material conflicts must remain visible.

VSIAM does not force a source assignment merely to complete the validation process.

Source Identity Conflict

Source identity itself may be disputed or ambiguous.

Examples include:

- duplicate identifiers,
 - renamed organizations,
 - model aliases,
 - shared accounts,
 - merged datasets,
 - copied documents,
 - cloned repositories,
-

- or uncertain system instances.

VSIAM requires sufficient distinguishability before identity-dependent reliability claims are made.

Source Identity Continuity

A source may change while remaining operationally connected to an earlier source identity.

Examples include:

- organization rename,
- ownership transfer,
- model update,
- database migration,
- instrument replacement,
- system upgrade,
- or repository transfer.

VSIAM preserves continuity where appropriate while ensuring that material changes remain visible.

Attribution Continuity

Evidence attribution should remain attached throughout the VALIDOS® lifecycle.

If evidence progresses through:

Evidence Fitness → Source Reliability → Validation Execution → Validation Determination

its source attribution should not disappear.

This allows later stages to reconstruct the source basis behind the validation result.

Source Identity Change

Material changes to source identity may require reassessment.

Triggers may include:

- version change,
- ownership change,
- source replacement,
- configuration change,
- instrument recalibration,
- model update,

- database migration,
- or corrected attribution.

A changed source does not automatically invalidate evidence.

But the source relationship must be reconsidered where the change is material.

Attribution Change

New information may change evidence attribution.

Possible outcomes include:

Attribution Confirmed

Attribution Strengthened

Attribution Restricted

Attribution Reassigned

Attribution Disputed

Attribution Withdrawn

Changes must remain traceable rather than overwriting the historical attribution record.

Identity and Attribution Are Not Provenance

VSIAM maintains a strict governance boundary.

It establishes:

Who or what is the source?

and:

Can this evidence be attributed to that source?

It does not reconstruct the complete history of how the evidence moved, transformed, or depended upon upstream sources.

That belongs to subsequent Source Provenance and Lineage governance.

This separation prevents duplication within VSRS.

Identity and Attribution Are Not Reliability

A perfectly identified and verified source may still be:

- incompetent,
- conflicted,
- dependent,
- incapable,
- compromised,
- or unreliable for the assigned role.

Therefore:

Verified Source Identity ≠ Source Reliability

and:

Verified Attribution ≠ Source Reliability

VSIAM establishes the foundation upon which reliability can later be assessed.

Minimum Implementation Framework

1. Identify Candidate Source

Determine the entity or entities claimed to have materially contributed the Validation Evidence.

2. Establish Source Identity

Record sufficient identifying information for the validation role.

3. Establish Source Instance and Version

Where materially relevant, identify:

- source instance,
- version,
- release,
- configuration,
- calibration state,
- or operational state.

4. Establish Source Role

Determine whether the source acted as:

- originator,
- observer,
- measurement source,
- recorder,
- provider,

- transmitter,
- transformer,
- aggregator,
- interpreter,
- repository,
- custodian,
- or another material role.

5. Establish Evidence Attribution

Determine the relationship between the evidence and each identified source.

6. Classify Attribution

Where appropriate, establish whether attribution is:

- Verified,
- Strong,
- Supported,
- Conditional,
- Uncertain,
- or Unattributed.

7. Identify Attribution Boundaries and Conflicts

Record limitations, assumptions, ambiguity, and material conflicts.

8. Preserve Identity and Attribution Continuity

Maintain the source relationship throughout subsequent VALIDOS® governance.

Identity & Attribution Output

VSIAM may produce:

- Validation Source Identifier,
- Validation Source Record,
- Source Instance Record,
- Source Version Record,
- Source Role Record,
- Evidence Attribution Record,
- Multi-Source Attribution Map,
- Attribution Strength Classification,
- Attribution Boundary Record,
- Attribution Conflict Record,
- Source Identity Conflict Record,
- Source Identity Change Record,
- Attribution Change Record,
- and Source Identity & Attribution Determination.

Use Case 1 — AI-Generated Analysis

Scenario

A validation process receives a technical analysis generated by an AI system and supplied through an enterprise platform.

Application

VSIAM distinguishes:

- the enterprise platform as Provider,
- the AI system as Interpreter or Generator,
- the model version where identifiable,
- and any separately identified underlying evidence sources.

Result

The validation process does not incorrectly treat the platform that delivered the analysis as the sole origin of the evidence.

The resulting attribution structure can proceed to provenance and reliability assessment.

Use Case 2 — Industrial Measurement

Scenario

A safety validation relies upon measurements contained in a contractor's report.

Application

VSIAM determines that:

- the contractor supplied the report,
- a specific sensor generated the measurements,
- a technician operated the measurement process,
- and the report aggregated the resulting records.

Result

The Validation Evidence is no longer represented as originating simply from "the contractor."

The relevant source roles become separately identifiable for subsequent reliability governance.

Use Case 3 — Internet Information

Scenario

A validation process identifies the same technical claim across multiple websites.

Application

VSIAM determines that several websites reproduce material originating from the same unidentified upstream source.

Result

The websites are not automatically treated as independent original sources.

Where original attribution cannot be established, the evidence retains an appropriate attribution limitation.

Architectural Position

Validation Source Identity & Attribution is the first internal governance space of the **Validation Source Reliability Standard (VSRS)**.

It creates the transition:

Validation Evidence → Identified Source → Defined Source Role → Evidence Attribution

The next VSRS governance stage can then examine:

Where did the evidence originate, through which pathway did it travel, and upon which upstream sources does it depend?

This preserves the progression:

Identity & Attribution → Provenance & Lineage → Capability & Competence → Independence & Conflict → Source Reliability Determination

Foundational Principle

A source cannot be reliably assessed until the evidence can be connected to who or what actually contributed it.

Canonical Closing Statement

Validation Source Identity & Attribution Module establishes the identity foundation of source reliability governance within VALIDOS®

by governing source identification, distinguishability, instances, versions, roles, attribution, attribution strength, multi-source relationships, boundaries, conflicts, change, and continuity. VSIAM ensures that Validation Evidence cannot acquire source-based confidence through anonymous, ambiguous, assumed, or incorrectly assigned origin, while creating the traceable source relationship required for subsequent provenance, capability, independence, conflict, and reliability governance.

Parent Resources

→ [VALIDOS® Validation Governance Architecture — Validation Governance Layer](#)

→ [VALIDOS® Architecture Map](#)

→ [VALIDOS® Complete Standards & Modules Index](#)

Internal Module Flow

→ [Next module: Validation Source Provenance & Lineage Module \(VSPLM\)](#)

Related Documents

→ [Validation Source Reliability Standard](#)

→ [About Validation Source Reliability Standard](#)

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